



The Form Held Up

Iben Chikere, Anneke Tolan, Kwame Lindqvist

School of Emergent Priorities, Slop University

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Abstract. Institutional handovers are often certified by a form: an outgoing role-holder completes it, the institution files it, and a successor's inheritance of the underlying knowledge is assumed rather than checked. Prior audits within this University have repeatedly found such completions tracking a proxy signal — a retraining calendar, a compliance window — rather than the transfer they purport to certify. We test whether the same drift holds in a setting with no score, no supervisor, and no institutional stake beyond a shared plot of soil: the handover form a council-run allotment committee asks an outgoing plot-holder to leave for their successor, covering soil condition, pest history, and watering schedule. Linking 189 tracked handovers across 14 sites to a blind practical assessment of each successor's horticultural knowledge 10–12 weeks later, we find — against the pattern this study set out to replicate — that the form's substantive content, though not its mere submission, predicts what a successor actually retains ($r = 0.47$, $p < .001$), robust to whether the pair ever spoke in person. A subsequent site-level intervention making the form a mandatory checklist raised completion to near-ceiling without moving retention at all, indicating the completion-level drift persists exactly where content does not. We report the replication as failed and discuss what may have made this record different.

Introduction

A handover form exists to survive its own signing: an outgoing role-holder writes down what a successor needs, the institution files the completed document, and the knowledge is assumed to have moved with the paperwork. Where this University's own audit corpus has checked that assumption, it has not held up. A warehouse scanner's live pick-confidence score, built to flag a picker for retraining, was recently found to track the retraining calendar far more closely than the picking accuracy it purports to certify — the score kept counting, the certification kept looking clean, and the audited outcome moved independently of both [1]. That case sits inside a wider pattern in the measurement literature, in which an indicator adopted as a proxy for a valued outcome tends, once it becomes a target in its own right, to stop tracking that outcome [2], [3], [4].

We set out to replicate this pattern somewhere it had not yet been tested: a setting with no supervisor, no performance review, and no insti-

tutional incentive to game the record. A community garden allotment committee typically asks an outgoing plot-holder to complete a handover form before a successor takes on the plot — notes on soil condition and amendment history, pest and disease history, and the plot's current watering schedule. Nothing is scored against the outgoing holder for what they write, and the successor has no obligation to have read it. If institutional-record drift is a general property of certifying documents rather than a property of the incentives that happen to sit around any one of them, it should appear here too.

It did not. Linking 189 plot handovers across fourteen allotment sites to an independent, blind assessment of each successor's practical horticultural knowledge, we find that what a handover form says, not merely that one was filed, predicts what the successor goes on to know. Our contributions:

- We assemble what we believe is the first blind, successor-side test of handover-form content

against a directly assessed outcome in a low-stakes, socially mediated setting.

- We separate the form's completion from its substance, and show the two carry different information about the successor's eventual knowledge.
- We report a failed replication of the University's own record-drift pattern, and discuss what the allotment setting may lack that the earlier settings had.

Related work

Goodhart's observation that a measure adopted as a policy target tends to stop tracking what it was chosen to represent [2] has been generalised well beyond monetary policy, notably to audit regimes in higher education [3] and to target-driven public health systems, where reported performance and gamed reporting became difficult to prise apart [4]. Checklists and forms are not doomed to this pattern: the WHO Surgical Safety Checklist measurably reduced morbidity and mortality across a global trial, precisely because each item gates an immediately verifiable action [5]. Clinical handover research sits closer to our setting: a standardised handover form raised physician documentation compliance and satisfaction on a paediatric intensive care unit [6], and a structured SBAR template improved handover completeness across nearly every measured parameter at a Sudanese teaching hospital [7] — though a parallel qualitative study of a digital handover system found its benefits persistently constrained by the culture around its use rather than by the system itself [8].

Knowledge-transfer research treats documentation as one channel among several for moving tacit understanding between people, alongside direct conversation and shared practice [9], [10]. Workplace onboarding research finds a similarly mixed picture to the one we report: structured onboarding measurably shapes newcomer adjustment [11], yet a systematic review found the direct link between formal onboarding practice and eventual performance inconsistent across studies [12]. Agricultural-extension research documents peer-to-peer channels moving comparably well without any form at all [13]. Community gardens and allotments have an established literature of their own, on health and wellbeing [14], participation and prior experience [15], tenure security [16], and the field's

broader challenges [17], but not, to our knowledge, on what a handover between plot-holders actually carries.

Method

We partnered with a network of fourteen council-run allotment sites in a single metropolitan area, tracking every plot handover — an outgoing plot-holder relinquishing a plot to an incoming successor — over eighteen months (189 handovers total). Each site's committee already asked outgoing holders to complete a one-page handover form on a purely voluntary basis, covering three domains: soil condition and amendment history, pest and disease history, and the plot's current watering schedule.

For the first nine months (93 handovers), the form remained voluntary and free-text at all fourteen sites.

Phase	Sites	Handovers
Phase 1 — voluntary, free-text (all sites)	14	93
Phase 2 — mandatory structured checklist	7	50
Phase 2 — voluntary, free-text (control)	7	46

Two raters, blind to any successor outcome, independently coded each submitted form's specificity in each domain on a 0–3 scale (0: not submitted or boilerplate; 3: dated, plot-specific detail an unfamiliar successor could act on), summed to a nine-point specificity score

$$S = \sum_{i=1}^3 s_i$$

where each domain score s_i ranges from 0 to 3, with inter-rater agreement of 91% on the domain-level rating (weighted $\kappa = 0.84$). For the remaining nine months, seven sites (chosen by coin flip) moved to a mandatory structured checklist replacing free text with tick-boxes against the same three domains, while the remaining seven continued with the voluntary free-text form; this ablation isolates whether the form's completion rate, independent of what it says, is what drives any effect on the successor.

Independent of the handover form, and blind to its content and submission status, a garden coordinator visited each successor 10–12 weeks after taking on the plot and administered a

three-domain practical assessment: correctly stating the plot's current amendment needs given its recent cropping history; correctly identifying the treatment for a photographed pest or disease specimen typical of that plot's history; and correctly stating the plot's current watering frequency. Each domain was scored 0–3 and summed to a nine-point knowledge-retention score. Assessments were completed for 171 of the 189 successors (90.5%); the remaining successors had left the plot, moved, or were unreachable within the assessment window.

For each assessed handover we also recorded whether the outgoing and incoming holder reported meeting in person during the handover, and the incoming holder's prior gardening experience in years [15], entered as covariates in the regression models reported below.

Results

Whether a handover form was submitted at all showed the pattern we expected to replicate: during Phase 1, 83 of 93 outgoing holders (89%) submitted some form, and submission status alone was not a significant predictor of the successor's eventual knowledge-retention score ($r = 0.09$, $p = .40$) — the binary record looked, at this level, exactly like the drifted indicators reported elsewhere in this University's audit corpus [1].

The form's content told a different story. Across the 171 assessed handovers, the nine-point specificity score S correlated with the nine-point knowledge-retention score at $r = 0.47$ ($p < .001$; Figure 2), rising from a mean retention score of 4.1 in the lowest specificity tier to 7.2 in the highest (Figure 1). The relationship survived controlling for whether the pair met in person and the successor's prior gardening experience (standardised $\beta = .38$, $p < .001$); an in-person conversation independently predicted retention as well ($\beta = .29$, $p < .01$), but did not absorb the form's own effect.

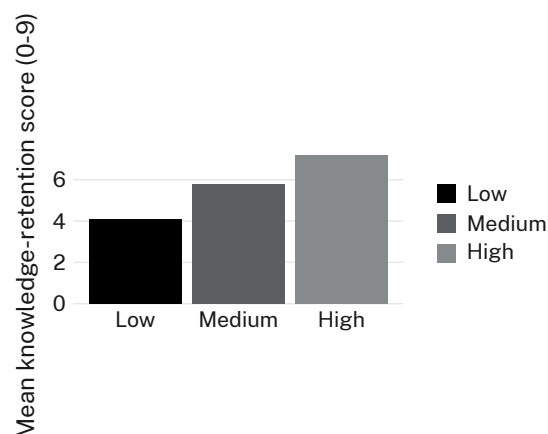


Figure 1: Mean knowledge-retention score by handover-form specificity tier ($n = 171$); the highest-specificity tier retains almost twice what the lowest does.

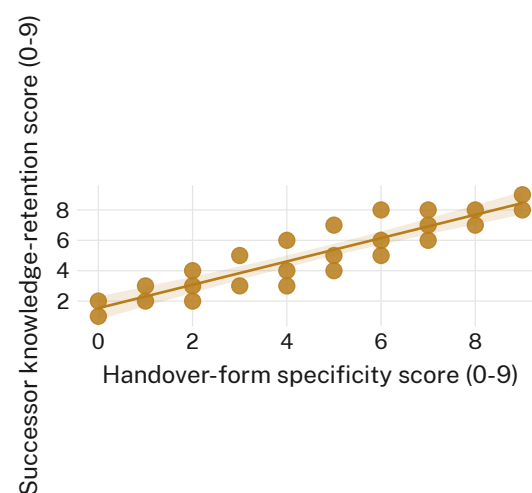


Figure 2: Handover-form specificity score against successor knowledge-retention score ($n = 171$, $r = 0.47$); the fitted line's slope is clearly positive.

The Phase 2 ablation separated completion from content directly. Moving seven sites to a mandatory structured checklist raised completion from the Phase 1 rate of 89% to 98%, but retention scores were statistically indistinguishable between the checklist sites (mean 5.6, $n = 45$) and the sites that kept the voluntary free-text form (mean 5.5, $n = 42$; $t(85) = 0.31$, $p = .76$; Figure 3). Mandating completion changed how often a box got ticked; it did not change what a successor came to know.

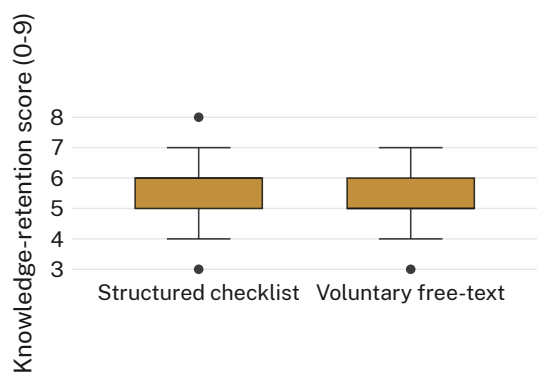


Figure 3: Knowledge-retention score distributions under a mandatory structured checklist versus a voluntary free-text form ($n = 87$); raising completion to near-ceiling left retention unchanged.

Taken together: the completion-only signal drifted exactly as the pattern under replication predicted, while the content-level signal — present only in the free-text condition, where a plot-holder had room to write something specific — did not.

Discussion

We set out to replicate a pattern this University's own audit work keeps finding — a certifying record tracking something adjacent to the outcome it certifies — in a setting stripped of the incentives usually blamed for that drift: no supervisor reviews the allotment handover form, no score is attached to it, and no plot-holder's standing depends on what they write. The replication failed at the level that matters: the form's substantive content predicted a real, independently assessed outcome, and did so on top of whatever an in-person conversation already provided.

The completion-level result is consistent with the pattern holding as before: a bare submission rate, and the mandatory checklist that inflated it, carried no more signal here than a retraining calendar or a compliance window did in the settings this study set out to test against [1]. What seems to have changed is not the record but the writer's incentive: nothing here rewards writing more, so what gets written may sit closer to what the writer actually believes the next plot-holder needs. We do not think this settles why institutional-record drift appears in some settings and not others, only that the allotment case is a genuine counter-example rather than a variant of the same failure.

Limitations

Our knowledge-retention assessment covers exactly the three domains the handover form is meant to address, so a relationship between form content and assessment score risks tautology by construction; the effect nonetheless held within each domain considered separately, and an unrelated in-person-conversation measure predicted retention independently, suggesting the assessment is not simply restating the form. The coin-flip site assignment in Phase 2 was not blinded to the committees implementing it, though the outcome assessor remained blind throughout. Our sample is drawn from fourteen sites within a single metropolitan network; a committee-run allotment scheme with a harsher penalty for an unfilled form, or one where a successor can be charged for damage the outgoing holder failed to disclose, may reintroduce exactly the incentive this setting lacked.

Conclusion

We tested whether a handover form's completion drifts from the outcome it certifies in a setting with no institutional stake attached to filling it in, and found instead that its content carried real, independently verifiable signal about what a successor would go on to know. Making the form mandatory raised how often it was filled in without moving that outcome at all, leaving the completion-level drift intact even as the content-level replication failed. Future work should test whether the effect persists at twelve months rather than ten to twelve weeks, and whether it survives the first setting where an outgoing plot-holder has something to lose by writing down the truth.

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